

on the outer surface, with the *Fencai* hundred children at play on white ground on the inner surface, and with the inscription 吉祥如意 (Luck and Auspiciousness) on the base, now in collection of the Palace Museum in Beijing. The plate, a masterpiece of Tongzhi Reign, was featured with bright colours and delicate and vivid drawings.

In the ninth year of Tongzhi Reign (AD 1870), the Imperial Factory produced one hundred pieces of large fish *Gang* for the Hall of Manifest Harmony where Dowager Cixi had her meals when she lived in the Hall of Preserved Elegance, as well as some other porcelain articles which totalled 10,000 pieces altogether. They all carried seals of the Hall of Manifest Harmony (體和殿) in Chinese characters. Besides fish *Gang*, the articles included the lantern-shaped *Zun*, the flower basin, and the case decorated with auspicious characters and patterns (*penghe*). These porcelains were heavy and thick, smoothly glazed and delicately decorated, similar to those of Daoguang Reign with the seals of the Hall of Prudent Morality (慎德堂) in Chinese characters. In the late Tongzhi Reign, porcelain production recovered from decline and began to boom in terms of production scale, quantity and quality. A kind of decorative pattern became very popular during this period, featuring light colours and flowing strokes of drawing, similar to the style of the Light Red Painting School of scholar painters. The kind of pattern had great influence on the porcelain drawings of Jingdezhen in the late Qing Dynasty.

Since the beginning of Guangxu Reign (AD 1875), the Imperial Factory produced large quantities of quality porcelains, including utensils both for the imperial family use and the sacrificial use. According to historical account, the first and second year of Guangxu Reign saw the production of large quantities of large *Gang* decorated with dragon patterns in *Qinghua*, *Fencai* and various other colourful glazes. There were also a lot of porcelains bearing seals indicating that they were made for the Palace of Eternal Spring (長春宮), the Hall of Earthly Tranquillity (坤寧宮) and the Hall of Preserved Elegance (儲秀宮), and etc. More than 175,500 taels of silver were spent on the production of porcelains especially for the celebrations of Cixi's 50th, 60th and 70th birthday. Besides, in the 17th year of Guangxu Reign (AD 1902), the Qing government ordered the supervisor-general of Imperial Factory Sun Tinglin to oversee the production of all porcelains for the Summer Palace. In recent years, the Wuning County Historical Relics Administration in Jiangxi Province has collected some porcelains made during Guangxu Reign at Dongken Village of the county's Yanyang Township, where Sun had once lived. Most of them were large porcelains demanding high production

techniques. Included in this book is a photo of the *Fencai* flower basin on yellow ground, decorated with 大雅齋 inscription, now in collection of Nanjing Museum. Right in the middle of the basin's cover were three Chinese characters in red meaning the Hall of Superb Elegance (大雅齋), with a seal meaning "universal spring (天地一家春)" decorated with double dragons playing pearl pattern on the right. The pot was a masterpiece of porcelains made during that stage. So porcelain production of Imperial Factory in Guangxu Reign ranked first in terms of varieties, quantities and quality compared with the production in other emperors' reigns in the late Qing Dynasty.

During Xuantong Reign, which lasted only three years (AD 1908-1911), Imperial Factory in Jingdezhen continued to produce porcelain articles and sacrificial utensils for the imperial court and the imperial family tombs: the East Tombs and the West Tombs. The few porcelains passed on to the later generations all demonstrate superb technological skills, characterised by high porcelain quality, thin and light texture, regular modelling and delicate patterns. Included in this book are pictures of some porcelain made in Xuantong Reign, all in collection of the Palace Museum. They were all with beautiful modelling, bright colours, and delicate, vivid drawings. This demonstrates that the Xuantong porcelains, though small in quantity, began to surpass their predecessors as long as production technological skills were concerned. Meanwhile, semi-mechanization appeared in rather large scale in the porcelain workshops of Jingdezhen. That explains why porcelains in this period had glassy glaze surface, shiny and bright. Printing patterns replaced manual drawing patterns on most of the porcelains, and stamps took the place of hand-written seals. All these were characteristics of modern porcelain.

There were a lot of famous porcelain craftsmen in the Guangxu and Xuantong reigns. Apart from the artistic types of the applied relief, the engraved, and the embossed, they further improved three-dimensional sculpture in terms of plastic arts and craftsmanship by learning from Western sculpture. Diamond-carved porcelain and porcelain-board portraits were considered new breakthroughs in porcelain production in Jingdezhen.

During the reigns of the Qing's last six emperors, porcelain production in either civilian kilns or Imperial Factory was characterised by the mass production of imitations of ancient porcelain.

The Jiaqing Reign saw far lower technological and artistic levels